in a consciously exclusive manner. Moreover, the negative connotations associated with the peace technical team were pronounced in its arrangements for 'out-of-the-public-eye gatherings', and spending of donor money on individual institutional projects. Nevertheless, the role of the team remained indispensable for sustaining the peace process throughout the tenure of the transitional government.

Secondly, my study has produced evidence that the MPC has been adopting piecemeal approaches with formal and informal binding in order to encourage the Tatmadaw and the EAGs to continue with the peace process. Although the government has adopted a three-phrase peace plan and certain ceasefire guidelines on paper, in terms of policy vision and practice, strategic negotiations are continuing under the piecemeal approach. The incremental approach allows the Tatmadaw and the EAGs to make small changes independently without taking much risk.

The piecemeal approach of the peace technical team enabled the government to sustain the peace process through formal and informal mechanisms. In my case study on "federal vision", if the Tatmadaw had to make dramatic changes by officially accommodating demands of the EAGs for a federal system and federal army at the same time, it is doubtful it would have been as willing to compromise. Likewise, informal binding with the EAGs on the 17(1) issue promoted trust in the government's commitment to the peace project. The facilitation of ethnic summits may not have helped the EAGs by resolving their long-awaited concerns, for example, being recognized as legitimate organizations, but the peace technical team's on-the-ground assistance to the EAGs helped earn their trust and bind them informally to the peace process. It further offered them incentives for a future settlement plan, encouraging adherence of the EAGs to the peace process. If the peace technical team had attempted to get the Unlawful Associations Act revoked, it could have posed a threat to the Tatmadaw by undermining its influence over the EAGs. In such a situation, it is unlikely that the Tatmadaw would have persisted with the peace process. All in all, despite the many political and security constraints, the role of the technical team as a policy apparatus along with its piecemeal approaches helped sustain the peace process until the end of the Thein Sein administration.